fighters were also heading to the south in search of combat there. Southern Afghanistan was a Taliban front, and it would be almost impossible for Lashkar militants to operate there unless they were integrated into Taliban units.[59]

Lashkar members are also suspected of participating in several joint attacks on Indian targets since autumn 2009. The first was a strike against the Indian Embassy in Kabul, which took place in early October of that year and killed seventeen people.[60] Two months later came an attack at the Heetal Hotel in Kabul, which was located next to a guest house in which approximately forty Indians were staying at the time. Lashkar members are believed to have helped orchestrate the operation, in which eight people were killed.[61] In February 2010 militants believed to belong to Lashkar and the Haqqani Network launched a complex attack against two guest houses in Kabul frequented by Indians. Eighteen people were killed, among them nine Indian nationals of which two were army doctors.[62] According to Afghan intelligence officials, some of the attackers spoke Urdu and searched specifically for Indians during the assault, including specifically demanding to know 'Where is the head Indian doctor?'. As with Mumbai, handlers outside of Afghanistan coordinated the attack via cellphone.[63]

Less than two weeks prior to the assault on the two guest houses in Kabul, homegrown jihadis executed the first successful terrorist attack in India since Mumbai. On 13 February 2010, they used a mobile phone alarm to set off a bomb, which ripped apart the German Bakery in the city of Pune killing seventeen people and injuring many more. The city hosts a diverse population as well as a growing IT sector, and the German Bakery was known as a frequent haunt for foreigners living there. It was also among those sites that David Headley had scouted for Abdur Rehman Syed. However, Indian authorities alleged that Mirza Himayat Baig was the mastermind behind the attack, hatching the plot and surveying the site himself. Baig was reputed to be Lashkar's top operative in the state of Maharashtra, in which the cities of Pune and Mumbai are located.[64] Officials from India's Anti-Terrorism Squad contend that he was in constant contact with Lashkar handlers while planning and preparing for the attack and that he relied upon operatives associated with the Indian Mujahideen for help executing the operation.[65] Indian officials viewed the Pune bombing as evidence that networks belonging to Lashkar and the